Mr. Magpie

An auction game for 3–5 critters, 20–25 minutes. Trade your winter acorns for Mr. Magpie's treasures, but he keeps every acorn you offer, win or lose.

BY DARREN DON



The goal. Collect the most points in treasures and baubles before the first snow. One catch: the critter with the **fewest acorns left** when the snow falls doesn't make it through winter and can't win, however much they collected.

Components



111 acorn cards
5 sets of 15 (1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 12, 14, 16, 18, 20)
and a 36-card acorn deck: eighteen 1s, twelve 2s, six 3s



18 treasure cards
14 treasures (5–15 points)
and 4 frosts (7–10 points)



78 bauble cards
13 each of earrings, berries, buttons, feathers, bottle caps and glass beads

Setup

1. Each critter takes one set of 15 acorn cards and keeps it **hidden in hand**. Put unused sets back in the box.

2. Shuffle the 18 treasure cards into a face-down deck.

3. Shuffle the bauble cards into a face-down deck, the **bag**. Leave room beside it for a face-up row of 8 baubles.

4. Leave room for Mr. Magpie's **larder**, a face-down pile for every acorn card offered.

5. Shuffle the 36-card **acorn deck** and put it face down, then pick a start player at random.

Acorn cards

Acorn cards are your money and your winter food. You can't make change: to offer 7 you need cards that add up to 7 or more, and whatever you put down is spent. Nobody may look at or count your hand, though they see every card you offer.

Mr. Magpie's deal

He keeps **every acorn anyone offers**, whether they win the treasure or not. But he never sends a guest home empty-handed: drop out of an auction and he thanks you with **one bauble for each acorn card** you offered.

Frosts

Four treasure cards are frosts. A frost is a secret auction. Everyone chooses any acorn cards from their hand (or none) and holds them out face down, then all reveal together.

The **biggest total wins** the frost. Everyone else who offered takes one bauble per card, biggest offering first, and anyone who offered nothing draws from the acorn deck. All offered cards go to the larder. If nobody offers, the frost stays out like any other treasure.

Tied for biggest? The tied critters offer again in secret, adding to what they brought, until the tie breaks. If none of them adds a card, nobody wins: the frost stays out and everyone who offered takes baubles.

Each treasure

1. **Show the treasure**
   Clear away any baubles left in the row and **deal 8 new ones** face up, then turn up the top treasure card. (When the bag runs out, shuffle the cleared baubles to make a new one.) If it's a frost, see **Frosts** on page 1. Whoever won the last treasure starts; if nobody won it, the start passes to the left.

2. **Offer or pass**
   Going clockwise, either **offer** or **pass**. To offer, lay acorn cards face up in front of you so that your total beats the top offering; cards you offered earlier still count. Nobody has to open. Once you pass you're out of this auction, but if you pass **without having offered anything, draw a card from the acorn deck** into your hand without showing it. It's a 1, a 2 or a 3, so nobody is ever stuck with nothing to bring.

3. **Drop out, take baubles**
   If you pass after offering, your cards go to the larder and you **take one bauble from the row for each acorn card you offered**, right away. So whoever drops out first picks first. You must take one for every card, even if nothing in the row helps you. If the row runs out, deal 8 more and keep taking.

4. **Last critter in wins**
   When only one critter with an offering is left, they take the treasure and their cards go to the larder. They get no baubles. A lone offering wins even if nobody else offered anything.

5. **Nobody offered?**
   The treasure **stays out**. Turn up the next card: whoever wins it takes the waiting treasure as well. Several can pile up this way.

Winter

When the **fourth frost** is turned up, the game ends at once. That frost isn't auctioned, and any treasure still waiting stays with Mr. Magpie.

Everyone shows their hand and adds up their acorns. The critter with the **fewest acorns doesn't make it through winter** and is out. If critters tie for fewest, they are all out (unless every critter is level, when nobody is).

Everyone else scores their treasures and baubles. **Most points wins**; if tied, the critter with more acorns wins.

Scoring baubles

Each treasure scores the points on its card. Baubles score as sets, as printed along the bottom of each card:

Earrings. Each pair scores +7. An earring left on its own scores –2.

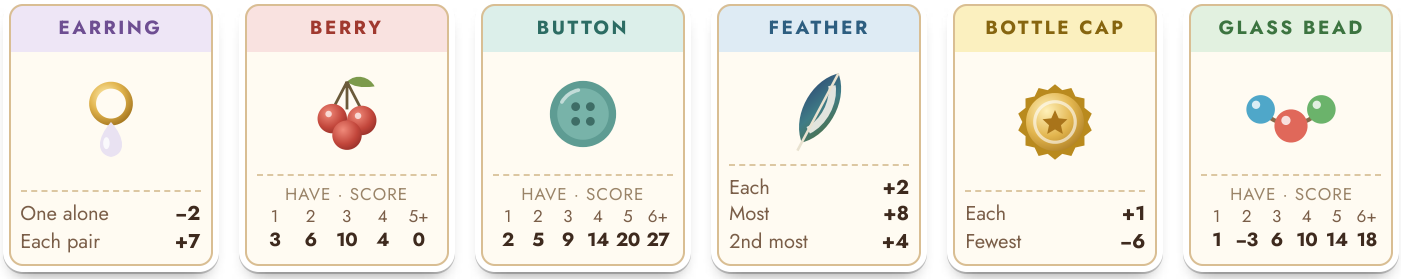
Berries. 1 to 5 berries score 3, 6, 10, 4, 0. A few are lovely, but too many spoil.

Buttons. 1 to 6 buttons score 2, 5, 9, 14, 20, 27. The bigger the collection, the better.

Feathers. +2 each. The critter with the most feathers scores 8 more and the second most 4 more. Tied critters all take the lower prize: a tie for most scores as second, and a tie for second scores nothing extra.

Glass beads. One bead scores 1 and two score –3, but three score 6, four 10, five 14 and six or more 18. Don't start a string you can't finish.

Bottle caps. +1 each, but the critter with the fewest caps scores –6, and having none counts as fewest. Tied for fewest? All of them lose the points, unless everyone is level.



Questions

Can I offer more than I need to? Yes, and without change you often have to. Extra cards also mean extra baubles if you drop out.

What if I have no acorn cards? Pass and draw from the acorn deck. A few passes and you're back in the bidding.

Do I get baubles for a treasure I win? No. Baubles only go to critters who offered and didn't win.

Is my collection secret? No. Treasures and baubles sit face up in front of you. Only your acorn hand is hidden.